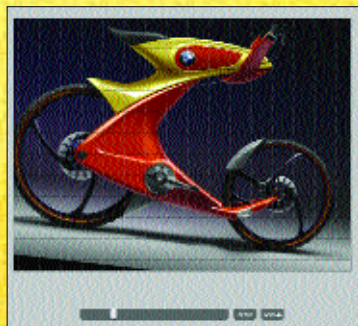


gory, for example, under the main tag 'people', you can add 'family', 'friends' etc. It also allows you to collect random photographs and group them as a collection (album). This comes in handy when you want to collect, say, all the photographs of cars that are on your hard disk, into one collection called 'Cars'.

Now, when you need to search for any particular file, you can do so using a tag. A point to note is that Photoshop Album 2.0 does not allow you to search by typing; it has checkboxes against the name of the tag. When you search by applying a particular tag, you select the check box against that tag. You can also check multiple boxes so that it does an 'or', 'and' and 'not' search. This search methodology is not available with Picasa 2.

Straightening Out Those Rough Edges

No matter how diligently you

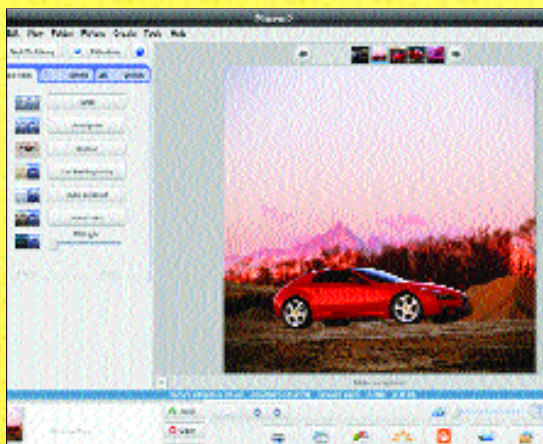


The 'Straighten' tool in Picasa 2 lets you correct wrongly-framed photos by simply moving the slider

take those pictures, they lack that extra bit, you think, would make them outstanding. In digital photography, the trick lies in post-shooting touch ups that can transform mediocre photographs into breathtaking shots. Red-eye, blur due to shaky hands, and dark photographs due to improper lighting are some common ailments in digital photography, and any image manager worth its salt should be able to correct these aberrations.

Picasa 2 comes with some neat, handy tools that let you play around with your photographs and bring in that professional touch. These tricks are divided into three categories—Basic Fixes, Tuning and Effects.

Basic Fixes offer a one-click solution for some common problems, such as Auto Contrast, Auto

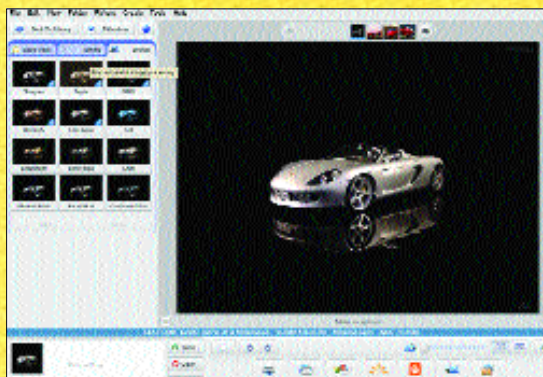


Fixes to the most common problems such as Red-eye are just a click away in Picasa 2

Colour, and Fill Light. It also consists of a 'Cropping' and a red-eye removal tool. One feature in particular that we found quite unique and interesting was the 'Straighten' tool. It allows you to straighten a tilted photograph i.e., it aligns the subject along the vertical axis.

'Tuning' provides that extra control over lighting conditions and shadows. Here, too, you have a one-touch correct option, which that does the magic, in case you fall short of the requisite creative ability.

Finally, 'Effects' allows you to



Your images can be enhanced by Effects such as 'Soft Blur' and Sepia tone in Picasa 2



Photoshop Album 2.0 lets you preview effects before you apply them

apply digital effects by using filters. In all, there are 12 effects that can be applied on the fly, at the click of a mouse. In case you don't like the final output, there's always 'Undo'!

Compared to Picasa 2, the touchup options in Photoshop Album 2.0 are limited, though it does offer the necessary tools cutting out the fancy bells and whistles.

For fixing your photographs, you need to click on the 'Fix' button in the main menu, which opens a window. The fixes are classified into General, Red-eye, Crop and Filters.

The fixing window has 'Before', 'After', and 'Before & After' panes that let you view the photo to be touched up in three versions as the names suggest. We found the 'Before & After' pane useful since the resultant effects after applying a fix are easy to notice.

For applying any fix in Photoshop Album 2.0, you need to click on the check box that automatically applies the fix. Clicking on the adjoining 'Expand' button reveals options for finer control over the fix.

Spreading The Warmth

The best part about digital photography is that you can make as many copies as you want at a click of a button and share them with friends and family. You can also put them up on your Web site, make an e-card, a photo-VCD, or a slideshow.

When it comes to sharing photographs, Picasa and Photoshop Album have some unique features. Photoshop Album 2.0, though, scores over Picasa, as it offers significant, yet unique and simple ways to share photos.

Photoshop Album 2.0 allows creation of your own albums, slideshows, VCDs, eCards, calendar, and photo book. It provides you with more templates than you would need for creating that special album or calendar.

In fact it requires just six steps to make any of the above (Refer explanation below). While slideshows are common, albums, calendars, and VCDs require some optimisation for proper printing and running. Photoshop Album 2.0 does all necessary optimisations for printing an album on your desktop printer.

Picasa 2 has options that help